5 AI Prompts That Turn Messy Meeting Notes into Sprint-Ready User Stories



By Ernestine Matjabo, Lead Product Owner and Senior Product Manager

ernestinematjabo.com

How to use this guide

Five prompts, one workflow: from raw meeting notes to a story your team can estimate.

1. Fill in your context block once (below) and keep it.

2. Copy a prompt, paste your context block and your own material where the brackets are.

3. Read the result against your notes. Check every number and every rule. The prompts are built to say "not stated" instead of guessing, but you stay the owner of the backlog.

All five examples use the same fictional case (a subscription pause for a food box). No real company, client or employer appears in this guide.

Works in ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or any assistant you use at work. Paste only what your company allows you to paste. Anonymize names and figures when in doubt.

Your context block (fill in once)

```
Product: [what it is, in one line]
Users: [who they are, what they care about]
Team conventions: [story format, what "ready for sprint" means for your team]
Constraints: [technical, legal, deadlines, anything the AI must not assume]
```

The five prompts

1. Turn messy meeting notes into decisions, open questions and stories
2. Split a story that is too big
3. Write Given/When/Then acceptance criteria from a story
4. Find edge cases and error cases
5. Review an AI-written story before refinement

The same fictional notes feed prompt 1, and the stories it produces feed prompts 2 to 5.

The fictional notes used in prompt 1

```
Meeting: subscription pause, sync 14/10 (Lena PM, Tom dev lead, Priya support, me)

- churn spike after holidays, support gets lots of "can't skip a week" tickets
- want users to be able to pause their box. how long? Priya says most ask 1-2 wks, some 1 month.
  Tom: max 4 wks ok technically, longer = billing job changes
- MUST NOT charge during pause (!!). what about boxes already packed? cutoff = Wed 18:00 before
  delivery?? Lena to check w/ ops
- email reminder before it resumes, 3 days?
- where in the app? account > subscription. web too (Priya: 60% of tickets come from web)
- Tom: resume date picker needs design, Sam
- no pause if payment failed (dunning)?? not sure
- discount offer when they try to cancel instead -> later, not now
- legal: nothing for now
- ACTIONS: Lena -> ops cutoff, Tom -> estimate billing change
```

1. Turn messy meeting notes into decisions, open questions and stories

Use it when: you leave a meeting with notes only you can read and need to know what was decided, what is still open and what can go to the sprint.

The prompt

```
You are helping a Product Owner turn raw meeting notes into sprint-ready user stories.

Context:
[paste your context block]

Raw notes:
[paste your notes]

Rules:
- A decision is something the notes say the team will do or will not do. A constraint, an
  unresolved discussion or an action item is not a decision. If one line mixes a firm part and a
  part with a question mark, split it: the firm part is a decision and the questioned part is an
  open question.
- Anything unclear, contradictory or marked with a question mark is an open question. Do not
  resolve it. If two questions are about the same blocker, merge them into one.
- Write stories only for what was clearly decided. A story must deliver an outcome for the user
  on its own. A menu entry, a button or a screen is not a story: fold it into the story that uses
  it. If a story is too big for one sprint, split it.
- Write acceptance criteria only from the notes or the context. Every criterion must be testable
  as written. Never write a criterion that refers to a rule "agreed", "defined" or "to be
  confirmed". If a criterion depends on an open question, leave it out of the story and put it in
  section 4.
- Every criterion must name something observable: what the user sees or receives, or what the
  system does. Do not restate the story in a criterion, and do not write two criteria that test
  the same thing.
- Never invent numbers, dates, rules or integrations. If something is missing, make it an open
  question.
- Mark every assumption with [ASSUMPTION] and keep them to a minimum. A criterion that describes
  behavior the notes do not mention must come with an [ASSUMPTION] line. Never write "None" if
  you added such a criterion.
- Keep the vocabulary used in the notes.
- Each blocker appears once, in section 4 only. Do not add dependency, readiness or next-step
  lines elsewhere.

Output format (follow it exactly, with no introduction and no conclusion, short enough to read in
two minutes):

## 1. Decisions
A table with the columns: # | Decision | Quote from the notes

## 2. Open questions
A table with the columns: # | Question | Why it matters | Who can answer (or "Not stated")
```

```
## 3. Stories
For each story, in this order:
### Story [number]: [short title]
One sentence: As a [specific user], I want [capability] so that [outcome].
Acceptance criteria: a numbered list of 2 to 5 criteria, each on its own line, each in Given /
When / Then form.
Assumptions: a bulleted list, or "None".

## 4. Not ready for sprint
A table with the columns: Story or part of a story | Blocked by question #

Do not add any other section.
```

Example

Input

```
The fictional notes above.
```

Output

---

1. Decisions

#	Decision	Quote from the notes
D1	Subscribers can pause their box	"want users to be able to pause their box"
D2	No charge while a subscription is paused	"MUST NOT charge during pause (!!)"
D3	Pause is available on web and in the app, from Account > Subscription	"account > subscription. web too"
D4	An email reminder is sent before the subscription resumes	"email reminder before it resumes"
D5	A discount offer at cancellation is out of scope for now	"later, not now"

2. Open questions

#	Question	Why it matters	Who can answer
Q1	What is the maximum pause length?	Support says 1 to 2 weeks for most users and 1 month for some. The dev lead says 4 weeks works, longer changes the billing job.	Lena, Tom
Q2	What happens to boxes already packed, and what is the cutoff?	"Wed 18:00??" is only a suggestion.	Lena, after checking with ops
Q3	How many days before resuming is the reminder sent?	"3 days?" is unconfirmed.	Not stated
Q4	Can a user pause when a payment has failed?	The notes say "not sure".	Not stated
Q5	Who owns the design of the resume date picker?	The notes say it needs design and mention Sam.	Not stated
Q6	How is billing handled when a subscription resumes?	The notes forbid charging during the pause but say nothing about the first charge after it.	Tom

3. Stories

Story 1: Pause from the account page

As a subscriber, I want to pause my subscription from Account > Subscription on web and in the app so that I do not receive boxes I cannot use.

Acceptance criteria

1. Given I am an active subscriber, when I open Account > Subscription on web or in the app, then I see an option to pause.
2. Given I choose to pause and confirm, when the action completes, then my subscription is shown as paused.
3. Given my subscription is paused, when I open Account > Subscription, then I see that it is paused.

Assumptions

- [ASSUMPTION] Pausing takes a single confirmation step. The notes do not describe the flow.

Story 2: No charge while paused

As a subscriber, I want not to be charged while my subscription is paused so that pausing really saves me money.

Acceptance criteria

1. Given my subscription is paused, when the billing job runs, then no charge is made.
2. Given my subscription is paused, when a billing date passes, then no new box is created for me.

Assumptions

- None

Story 3: Reminder before resuming

As a subscriber with a paused subscription, I want an email before my subscription resumes so that a charge does not surprise me.

Acceptance criteria

1. Given my subscription is paused and has a resume date, when the reminder time is reached, then I receive an email saying the subscription will resume.
2. Given my subscription is not paused, when its next billing date approaches, then I do not receive a resume reminder.

Assumptions

- None

4. Not ready for sprint

Story or part of a story	Blocked by question #
Story 1: choosing a pause length	Q1
Story 1 and Story 2: boxes already packed	Q2
Story 2: first charge after resuming	Q6
Story 3: reminder timing	Q3
Pausing after a failed payment	Q4
Resume date picker	Q5

Watch for: constraints or action items listed as decisions; the same blocker repeated as several questions; a story for a menu entry that delivers nothing alone; criteria that point to a rule "agreed by the team" instead of stating it; criteria added beyond your notes without an assumption flag. Check every number and every rule against your notes.

2. Split a story that is too big

Use it when: a story will not fit in one sprint, or the team cannot estimate it.

The prompt

```
You are helping a Product Owner split a story that is too big for one sprint.

Context:
[paste your context block]

The story:
[paste the story, plus any notes about it]

Rules:
- Split into vertical slices: each slice must deliver something a user can see or do on its own.
  Never split by technical layer (database, API, front end) or by role (design, dev, test).
- The first slice must be the smallest one that delivers real value, even if it is basic.
- Use only what the story, the notes and the context say. Never invent numbers, rules or
  integrations. Anything missing becomes an open question.
- Mark every assumption with [ASSUMPTION].
- If a part of the story depends on an open question, say so once, in the slices table, and
  nowhere else.
- Keep the vocabulary used in the story.
- If the story is already small enough, say so in one sentence and stop.

Output format (follow it exactly, no introduction, no conclusion):

## 1. Why it is too big
Two or three bullets, each tied to something in the story.

## 2. Slices
A table with the columns: # | Slice (short title) | What the user can do afterwards | Depends on
| Open question

## 3. Suggested order
A numbered list of the slice numbers, one line each, with the reason for the order.

## 4. Left out on purpose
A bulleted list of what you did not turn into a slice, or "None".

Do not add any other section.
```

Example

Input

```
As a subscriber, I want to pause my subscription from Account > Subscription, on web and in the
app, for a length I choose, with an email reminder before it resumes and no charge during the
pause, so that I do not receive boxes I cannot use.

Notes: Priya says most users ask for 1 to 2 weeks, some for 1 month. Max length not decided.
Resume date picker needs design. Reminder timing not decided ("3 days?"). Boxes already packed:
cutoff to be checked with ops.
```

Output

1. Why it is too big

- It covers four behaviors: pausing, choosing a length, not being charged, and a reminder email.
- It spans two platforms, web and app.
- Three parts are still undecided: the maximum length, the reminder timing, and boxes already packed.

2. Slices

#	Slice	What the user can do afterwards	Depends on	Open question
1	Pause on web, fixed default length	Pause the subscription from Account > Subscription and see it as paused	Nothing	Which default length?
2	No charge while paused	Stay uncharged for the whole pause	Slice 1	None
3	Pause in the app	Do the same as slice 1 from the app	Slice 1	None
4	Choose the pause length	Pick a length instead of the default	Slice 1	Maximum length, resume date picker design
5	Reminder email before resuming	Receive an email before the subscription resumes	Slice 1	Reminder timing
6	Boxes already packed	Pause even when the next box is already packed	Slice 1	Cutoff from ops

3. Suggested order

1. Slice 1, because everything else builds on a working pause.
2. Slice 2, because "do not charge during the pause" is the one rule the notes mark as a must.
3. Slice 3, because the notes say 60% of tickets come from the web, so web first and app next.
4. Slices 4, 5, 6 as soon as their open question is answered.

4. Left out on purpose

- The discount offer at cancellation: the notes say "later, not now".

Watch for: splits by technical layer (database, API, front end) instead of by what the user can do afterwards, and for rules invented to fill a gap.

3. Write Given/When/Then acceptance criteria from a story

Use it when: a story is clear but its acceptance criteria are missing, vague or inconsistent.

The prompt

```
You are helping a Product Owner write acceptance criteria.

Context:
[paste your context block]

The story:
[paste the story and any notes about it]

Rules:
- Write 2 to 5 criteria in Given / When / Then form, each on its own line.
- Every criterion must name something observable: what the user sees or receives, or what the
  system does. Do not restate the story in a criterion.
- Every criterion must be testable as written. Never refer to a rule "agreed", "defined" or "to
  be confirmed".
- Do not write two criteria that test the same thing.
- Use only what the story, the notes and the context say. Never invent numbers, dates, rules or
  integrations.
- A criterion that describes behavior the notes do not mention must be listed under Assumptions
  with [ASSUMPTION]. Never write "None" if you added one.
- If a behavior cannot be tested yet because something is undecided, do not write a criterion for
  it. List it under "Not testable yet" with the missing information.
- Keep the vocabulary used in the story.

Output format (follow it exactly, no introduction, no conclusion):

## Acceptance criteria
A numbered list in Given / When / Then form.

## Assumptions
A bulleted list, or "None".

## Not testable yet
A table with the columns: Behavior | Missing information

Do not add any other section.
```

Example

Input

```
As a subscriber with a paused subscription, I want an email before my subscription resumes so
that a charge does not surprise me.

Notes: reminder email before it resumes, "3 days?" not confirmed. Emails go through the existing
email provider.
```

Output

Acceptance criteria

1. Given my subscription is paused with a resume date, when the reminder time is reached, then I receive an email telling me the subscription will resume and on which date.
2. Given I have already received the reminder for this resume date, when the next scheduled run happens, then I do not receive a second reminder for the same date.
3. Given my subscription is not paused, when its next billing date approaches, then I do not receive a resume reminder.

Assumptions

- [ASSUMPTION] The email states the resume date. The notes only say there is a reminder.
- [ASSUMPTION] One reminder is sent per resume date. The notes do not say how many.

Not testable yet

Behavior	Missing information
How long before resuming the email is sent	The notes say "3 days?", not confirmed

Watch for: criteria that restate the story ("then my subscription is paused"), two criteria that test the same thing, and wording like "works correctly" that nobody can test.

4. Find edge cases and error cases

Use it when: criteria look complete but you suspect the story will break on the unusual path.

The prompt

```
You are helping a Product Owner find the edge cases and error cases of a story before refinement.

Context:
[paste your context block]

The story and its acceptance criteria:
[paste them]

Rules:
- List at most 10 cases. Keep the ones where a user could be harmed (wrongly charged, blocked,
  misinformed) or where the team is likely to disagree.
- Classify each case as Edge (unusual but valid) or Error (something fails).
- Never decide the expected behavior yourself. If the story, the criteria or the context state
  it, quote where. If not, write "Not stated" and turn the case into a question for the team.
- Do not repeat a case already covered by an acceptance criterion.
- Never invent numbers, dates, rules or integrations.
- Keep the vocabulary used in the story.

Output format (follow it exactly, no introduction, no conclusion):

## Cases
A table with the columns: # | Case | Type (Edge or Error) | Expected behavior (quoted source or
"Not stated") | Risk if ignored (High, Medium or Low)

## Questions for the team
A numbered list, one question per "Not stated" case, written so that someone can answer in one
sentence, with who is likely to know.

Do not add any other section.
```

Example

Input

```
Story: As a subscriber, I want not to be charged while my subscription is paused so that pausing
really saves me money.
Criteria: 1. Given my subscription is paused, when the billing job runs, then no charge is made.
2. Given my subscription is paused, when a billing date passes, then no new box is created for
me.
Context: The notes say the rule is a must. Boxes already packed: cutoff to be checked with ops.
Payment failure handling ("dunning") exists.
```

Output

Cases

#	Case	Type	Expected behavior	Risk if ignored
1	The user pauses after the box is already packed	Edge	Not stated	High
2	The user pauses on the billing date itself, before the job runs	Edge	Not stated	High
3	The user pauses while a payment has failed and is being retried	Edge	Not stated	High
4	The billing job fails or is delayed during the pause	Error	Not stated	Medium
5	The pause request fails after the user confirms	Error	Not stated	Medium
6	The user pauses from the app and the web at the same time	Edge	Not stated	Low

Questions for the team

1. Is a box that is already packed still sent and charged, and what is the cutoff? (Lena, with ops)
2. If a user pauses on the billing date, which comes first, the pause or the charge? (Tom)
3. Can a user with a failed payment pause, and what happens to the retries? (Not stated)
4. If the billing job runs late, how do we make sure a paused user is still not charged? (Tom)
5. What does the user see if the pause request fails? (Not stated)
6. Which request wins if two pauses arrive at once? (Tom)

Watch for: the AI deciding the expected behavior itself instead of asking, and cases already covered by an existing criterion.

5. Review an AI-written story before refinement

Use it when: an AI (or a colleague in a hurry) wrote a story and you must decide if it can go to refinement.

The prompt

```
You are a demanding Product Owner reviewing a user story before refinement.

Context:
[paste your context block]

The story to review:
[paste the story and its criteria]

Rules:
- Check each point: a specific user (not "a user"), an outcome the user would notice, a size that
  fits one sprint, criteria that are testable as written, no invented details, nothing that
  depends on an undecided point.
- Quote the exact words that are wrong. Do not write a general comment without a quote.
- A problem is only a problem if you can say what would go wrong in refinement or in the sprint.
- Do not rewrite the whole story unless the verdict is "Needs work". If the verdict is "Not
  ready", say what is missing instead.
- Never invent numbers, rules or integrations in the rewrite. Mark every assumption with
  [ASSUMPTION].

Output format (follow it exactly, no introduction, no conclusion):

## Verdict
One word: Ready, Needs work or Not ready. Then one sentence of reason.

## Problems
A table with the columns: # | Quote | What goes wrong | Fix

## Rewritten story
Only if the verdict is "Needs work". The story and its criteria, with assumptions marked.

Do not add any other section.
```

Example

Input

```
As a user, I want a modern pause feature so that retention improves.
Acceptance criteria:
1. The pause works correctly.
2. The system is fast.
3. The interface is user-friendly and follows the agreed design.
```

Output

Verdict

Not ready. The story names no specific user, no outcome the user would notice and no testable criterion.

Problems

#	Quote	What goes wrong	Fix
1	"As a user"	Not a specific user, so nobody knows who gets the pause	Say who: for example an active subscriber
2	"a modern pause feature"	"Modern" is not a capability, so the team cannot tell what to build	State what the user can do: pause, for how long, from where
3	"so that retention improves"	A business goal, not an outcome the user would notice, and not verifiable in a sprint	State what the user gains, for example not receiving boxes they cannot use
4	"The pause works correctly"	Cannot be tested: "correctly" is not defined	Name what is observable: the subscription shows as paused, no charge is made
5	"The system is fast"	No threshold, so QA cannot pass or fail it	Give a measurable target, or remove it
6	"follows the agreed design"	Refers to a design that is not attached to the story	Attach the design or remove the criterion

Rewritten story

Not provided: the verdict is "Not ready". Missing before it can be written: who can pause, for how long, from which screens, and what the user must see afterwards.

Watch for: a polite verdict that hides the problems, and fixes that invent details the story never had.

What is next

This guide is 5 prompts out of 25. The full PO Prompt Pack covers stories, acceptance criteria, PRDs and scoping, prioritization, retros and ceremonies, delivered as a PDF and a Notion database. It is available now: get the full PO Prompt Pack.

One question, and I read every message: which story are you stuck on right now? Tell me on ernestinematjabo.com.

Ernestine Matjabo

Lead Product Owner and Senior Product Manager, 9+ years in digital product, fintech and e-commerce

ernestinematjabo.com



Thank you

ernestinematjabo.com